

about this. Building a network is not an excuse to mindlessly drop hundreds of dollars a month on unhealthy fast food while sitting around complaining about office politics. It means strategically spending time and money to develop meaningful connections with people who can positively influence your life.

Author and speaker Brian Tracy advises everyone to “invest 3% of your income in yourself to guarantee your future.” As a valuer, I hate arbitrary rules about spending, but I love the underlying principle of investing in yourself. I suggest putting part of that investment toward building your social network. There are many ways you can do this, ranging from small things like going out to lunch with coworkers, to larger expenses, like going to a conference instead of opting for online tools to learn new skills. This is a small amount to invest with massive upside potential if you develop real relationships that can transform your life.

Scott Trench, author of the book *Set for Life* and cohost of the podcast *BiggerPockets Money*, shared a great example of this principle in action when he talked with Brad and Jonathan on the *ChooseFI* podcast. Scott shared the story of how he was invited to sit in on the meetings of a mastermind group of real estate investors when he was in his early twenties. He'd been invited by an older